

Poor Shane. My brother was younger than me and always good with money. I went to him next. (See why I say borrowing money from family is fraught with problems? But hey, I was young then, and didn't know any better.) I pleaded, I begged, I told him he was the best brother in the world. In the end, he helped me out. Then, I got another job and I paid him back over the course of several months, with no interest. But I will never forget the emotional turmoil that that purchase created in me: from the heady opiate of owning something with so much power and promise, to the gut-wrenching fear that same purchase produced when I realized I couldn't afford what I had wanted so badly. What a terrible disconnection: to have something in my possession that wasn't really mine, and yet to be unable to give it back. And yet, this is a state that a lot of people exist in, day in and day out, people with massive credit card debt, who screen their calls, who consistently live beyond their means. I was lucky that my decision wasn't catastrophic. But I was shaken. I had put myself in jeopardy. I felt it to my core. And yet I also know that at the time, I was powerless to resist that stereo.

Since then, I have never carried a credit card balance. I have never paid only the minimum payment, because in my mind I began to double the price of everything I bought with a credit card. If a pair of skis cost \$500, in my head I made them cost \$1,000. "Now can you afford them?" I asked myself. From that moment on, credit was about convenience only. It was never a shortcut to consumer joy.

So I know how easy it is to get caught up in that whirlwind of consumer enthusiasm. When you stand in front of something you want, you can feel the beginnings of consumer intoxication taking effect. It's powerful when it's mixed with teenage hormones, which is precisely how big-box electronic stores can get young people to make big purchases. Those places are like nightclubs, with pounding music and visual overload at every turn. Gadgets are how teens measure their coolness and value. It was true when I was kid and it's true now. Everything's all about bigger, better, and faster. It always was. And it's impossible not to get caught up in spending way more than you can afford, because "want" takes over for "need." And here's the crazy part: We let it happen.